



WEEK TWO · MODULE ONE

The Codes of Luxury

The culture and etiquette that signal, instantly, whether you belong

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

Read the module once, then read the Dictionary of Luxury from beginning to end. This week assumes it.

Read the module a second time with a pen. You are looking for your own errors, not for other people's.

Nobody will ever correct you in this world. They will simply, quietly, stop entrusting you with things.

That is why this week exists.

CHAPTER I

What a code is

And why it cannot be faked for long

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Define a code, and distinguish it from a rule.

Understand why codes exist, and what they are actually for.

Accept the two-year rule of cultural fluency.

I.1 · A definition

DEFINITION

A **code**. A shared, unwritten convention by which a group recognises its own. Codes are never explained to newcomers, because explaining them would destroy their function.

That last clause is the whole of it. A rule can be published, learned and obeyed. A code cannot, because its purpose is precisely to distinguish those who had to learn it from those who did not. This is not cruelty; it is how every closed group on earth protects itself, from a village to a boardroom to a family.

I.2 · What codes are actually for

You will be tempted to find them absurd. Why should it matter whether one says *settee* or *sofa*, whether the napkin goes left or right, whether one calls a wine "nice"? It matters for a reason that has nothing to do with the words: **a code is a cheap and instant test of belonging**. A family cannot investigate everyone who enters their life. They rely on a thousand small signals, processed in seconds, mostly unconsciously.

And here is the consequence that governs your entire career: **you will not be corrected**. A guest will not tell you that you used the wrong word. A principal will not explain that you were too loud. They will simply feel, faintly, that you are not quite right, and they will begin, without deciding to, to hand you less. By the time you notice, it will be over.

I.3 · The honest timeline

HOW LONG THIS TAKES

You will learn the vocabulary in a week. You will learn to *use* it in a year.

The vocabulary is the easy half. The hard half is the restraint: knowing which of the things you now know should never be said at all.

The single fastest way to be identified as an outsider is to demonstrate that you have recently learned the codes. Study everything. Display nothing.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

A code is an unwritten test of belonging, and it is never explained to you.

You will not be corrected. You will simply be trusted less, and you will not know why.

Learn everything. Display nothing. The display is itself the error.

CHAPTER II

The language

The words that betray you, and the ones that never appear

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

List the words that are never used by people who live inside this world.

Replace description with precision.

Understand the mathematics of the word "luxury".

2.1 · The rule, and it is almost mathematical

The more a person says the word "luxury", the further they are from it. The people who live inside this world do not describe it, because to describe it would be to stand outside it and point. They name things precisely, and then they stop talking.

This is the single most useful test you will learn this week, and you can apply it to anyone, including yourself, within thirty seconds of meeting them.

Never said

Said instead

"A luxury car."	The marque. "The Bentley." "The old Land Rover." Nothing more.
"A fine wine."	The estate, and the year. Or nothing at all, and a small nod.
"An exclusive club."	Its name, said quietly, once, and only if it is relevant.
"A VIP guest."	A guest. There are no other kinds.
"An iconic piece."	Iconic is used perhaps twice a decade. Its power is entirely in its scarcity.
"High-end", "upscale", "prestigious", "premium".	Nothing. These are the words of the people who sell this world to the people who are not in it.
"Amazing", "incredible", "stunning".	"Lovely." "Very good." "That was a pleasure." Understatement is not modesty here; it is fluency.

2.2 · The vocabulary of the professional

Certain words mark you immediately as someone who knows the house, and they cost nothing to adopt today.

Word	Why it matters
Principal	The person you serve. Never "boss", never "client", never "employer". This single word is the most efficient signal available to you.
The office	The family office. "I will confirm with the office" is one of the most useful sentences you will ever own.
Certainly	The correct answer to almost anything. Not "no problem", not "sure", not "of course" (which can sound like impatience).
The house	The household as an organisation, not the building.
A gentleman / a guest	Never "a client". You are not in hospitality any more.
I will see to it	The sentence that ends a conversation cleanly, and promises exactly what it says.

2.3 · The great error: bluffing a reference

You will one day be in a room where a name is mentioned, and you will not know it. A house, a vineyard, a designer, a school, a village in Switzerland. Every instinct will tell you to nod as though you knew.

Do not. This world is small, and the bluff is detected almost immediately, and it is remembered for years. The professional says, without embarrassment: *"I don't know it. Tell me."* That sentence costs you nothing, and it frequently earns you something, because people enjoy explaining what they love.

The rule beneath the rule: **a confident error is far more damaging than an honest gap.** Ignorance is temporary. A reputation for bluffing is not.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The word "luxury" is a distance marker. The people inside never use it.

Replace description with precision: the marque, the estate, the year, or nothing.

Say "principal", say "certainly", say "I will see to it".

Never bluff a reference. Say "I don't know it. Tell me."

CHAPTER III

The register

How one speaks inside a private house

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Adopt the correct forms of address, and hold them under pressure.
- Master the four sentences that will carry ninety per cent of your conversations.
- Understand why brevity is the deepest code of all.

3.1 · Forms of address

- **Follow the house, exactly.** Some households are first names from the first day. Others are Madame and Monsieur for a decade. Neither is more correct; what is incorrect is guessing.
- **If first names are offered, accept once, and never in front of guests.** In public you revert. This protects the principal, and it protects you.
- **Never use a diminutive.** Not for the principal, not for the children, not for a colleague in front of the family.
- **Address the guest as the family addresses them.** Listen for thirty seconds before you speak, and you will never be wrong.

3.2 · The four sentences

Learn these by heart. They will carry you through most of a working life, and each one is a code in itself.

THE FOUR SENTENCES

- "Certainly." The answer to a request. It closes without flourish, and it commits.
- "I will see to it." When the matter is now yours, and they need never think of it again.
- "Leave it with me." Warmer, for the small things, and it removes the burden visibly.
- "I am not able to help with that, but let me pass it to the office." The refusal. Calm, complete, and without argument. Learn it in the exact words.

3.3 · Brevity, and why it is the deepest code

The length of your sentences is a status signal, and almost nobody realises it. The person who explains at length is asking for something: understanding, credit, forgiveness, admiration. The person who says four words and stops is asking for nothing.

So: **never explain how hard it was.** Never narrate the obstacles. Never say "I finally managed to". The correct account of a difficult afternoon is: *"It is arranged."* If they wish to know more, they will ask, and they almost never will.

And write as you speak. An email of four lines from a member of staff reads as competence. An email of twenty lines reads as anxiety, and anxiety is contagious, which is why they will stop reading you.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Follow the house on names. Revert to the formal register in public, always.

Certainly. I will see to it. Leave it with me. I am not able to help with that.

Brevity is the code beneath all the others. Never explain how hard it was.

CHAPTER IV

The body

Presence, dress, and the art of being unmemorable

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Dress correctly for a private household, which is not the same as dressing well.

Manage your physical presence in a room.

Eliminate the six physical tells that identify an outsider instantly.

4.1 · The governing rule of dress

Always one level below the family. Never above. This is not humility; it is function. Your clothing exists to make you legible and forgettable, so that attention flows past you to where it belongs.

THE TEST

If a guest could describe what you were wearing an hour later, you were wearing the wrong thing.

Simple. Impeccable. Unmemorable. Excellent fabric, no visible brand, nothing that moves, nothing that makes a sound.

- **No visible logo.** Anywhere, on anything you own, including your bag and your telephone case. A logo announces that the object was expensive, which is the one thing this world never announces.
- **Nothing that sounds.** Bracelets that chime, heels that announce you on a stone floor, keys that jingle. You must be able to enter a room without being heard.
- **Perfume: almost none, and never in the morning.** A scent that arrives before you is a form of talking.
- **Nails, hair, hands: immaculate and undramatic.** Your hands will be six inches from a principal's plate and their children's faces. They will be looked at more than your face.
- **Shoes clean, always, including the heel.** Old money looks at shoes. It is an ancient reflex and it has not weakened.

4.2 · Presence

Presence is not charisma. In this world it is the opposite: it is the ability to be entirely available and entirely unobtrusive at the same time.

- **Enter quietly, and pause at the threshold.** Never cross a room while someone is speaking.
- **Stand still.** Fidgeting, shifting, checking, adjusting: all of it reads as anxiety, and anxiety in staff makes a family anxious.

- **Do not fill silences.** The person who is comfortable in a silence is the person who is trusted in it.
- **Never sit unless invited, and never eat in front of the family unless invited twice.**
- **Leave before you are noticed leaving.** The exit is part of the service.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

One level below the family, always. If they can describe your clothes, they were wrong.

No logo, no sound, no scent, no drama. Immaculate hands, clean shoes.

Enter quietly, stand still, say less, leave before you are noticed leaving.

CHAPTER V

The table

The one arena in which you will be tested in public

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Lay and read a formal table without hesitation.

Know the service conventions, and the errors that are visible to everyone.

Speak about wine and food precisely, or not at all.

5.1 · Why the table matters more than anything else

Because it is the only place where your competence is on display to the family, to their guests, and to the other staff, simultaneously, in real time. An error at the table is not private. It is theatre.

5.2 · The essentials, and they are not negotiable

Convention	The rule
Cutlery	Outside in, working towards the plate as the meal progresses. Dessert cutlery above the plate. The guest never has to wonder.
Glasses	Above the knives, to the right. Water, then white, then red, ordered by the shape of the glass. Champagne where the house prefers it.
Service	From the left when serving, from the right when clearing. Wine poured from the right. Never reach across a guest, ever.
Silver service	Food transferred from platter to plate with a spoon and fork held in one hand. It is a genuine skill; where it is expected, clumsiness is instantly visible, and where it is not, using it looks like a performance.
Napkins	Placed, not folded into shapes. A folded swan is a code, and the code it sends is "hotel".
Clearing	Never clear a plate until everyone has finished. Never stack. Never scrape at the table.
The pause	A guest who rests their cutlery on the plate at an angle is not finished. Crossed or together, they are. Learn to read this from across a room.

5.3 · Speaking about wine

The safest posture in the world of wine is **curiosity, never authority**. A sommelier respects the person who asks a good question far more than the person who performs knowledge.

- Never say a wine is "nice", and never say it is "amazing". Say what it does: it is fresh, it is closed, it needs air, it is drinking beautifully now.
- Offer to decant a mature red without being asked. It is a gesture of care, and it improves the thing they are about to enjoy.
- Know that serious Champagne is increasingly served in a white wine glass rather than a flute, to release the aroma. Knowing this quietly is a mark of real fluency.
- Suggest a magnum for a large table and a half bottle for a solitary diner. Both show an eye for the occasion rather than for the price.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The table is the only public examination of your competence. Prepare for it accordingly.

Outside in. Left to serve, right to clear. Never reach across a guest.

On wine: curiosity, never authority. Describe what it does, not how much you like it.

CHAPTER VI

The material codes

What objects say, and what they never say

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Read a room, and understand what its objects are telling you.

Distinguish inherited taste from purchased taste, without ever remarking on either.

Code	What it signals
Patina	The soft wear of age on leather, silver, wood, a watch. Old money treasures it as proof of endurance. Never polish it away, never remark on it, and never apologise for it.
The monogram	Discreet, tone on tone, small, on linen or luggage. Large and contrasting is a different signal entirely, and not the one you want.
Flowers	Loose, seasonal, from a garden if possible. A tight commercial arrangement in cellophane reads as "ordered", and ordered is the opposite of arranged.
Fresh vs new	Old money buys once and repairs. New money replaces. Neither is your business, and both change how you manage a house, a budget and a supplier.
Silence	A house with soft closing doors, felt under objects, and no ringing telephones is a house that has spent money on quiet. Quiet is the most expensive commodity in this world, and you are, in large part, employed to produce it.
The absence of things	An empty console with a single object on it costs more than a full one. Restraint is the code that contains all the other codes.

And a warning that costs people their positions: **never comment on the value of anything.** Not the art, not the watch, not the car, not the house. Not to admire it, not to praise it, not even to compliment the taste behind it. Noticing the price of things is the single clearest signal that one is not accustomed to them.

CHAPTER VII

The dress codes, decoded

What an invitation is actually saying

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Read any invitation correctly, at a glance.

Prepare a principal without ever appearing to correct them.

On the invitation

What it means

White tie	The most formal. Black tailcoat, white waistcoat, white bow tie; for women, a full-length gown. Rare, exacting, and unforgiving of error.
Black tie	Dinner jacket, black bow tie; gown or elegant cocktail dress. A business suit here is a quiet failure, and it will be seen by everyone.
Black tie optional	It is not optional. Wear black tie.
Cocktail	Short dress, dark suit. The most misread of all the codes, and the one where people most often overdress.
Smart casual	A jacket, no tie. On the Riviera in August, a linen jacket and no socks. It is the hardest code, because it has no rules and everyone is watching.
Resort / beach formal	Linen, colour, no tie, no jacket after sunset. Extremely easy to get wrong by trying.

YOUR ROLE IN THIS

You will one day see a principal about to leave for an evening dressed incorrectly for it.

You do not correct them. You say: *"The invitation says black tie, if that is useful."* Then you say nothing further, and you look at something else.

You have given them the fact. What they do with it is theirs. That sentence, delivered without a flicker of judgement, is worth more than any qualification you will ever hold.

CHAPTER VIII

The cultural map

The codes are not the same everywhere, and the difference matters

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Adjust the codes to the culture of the house you serve.

Avoid the classic error of applying English or French codes universally.

World	What changes
Old European money	Understatement, patina, tradition, and an acute sensitivity to language. They will forgive a lapse in service far more readily than a lapse in manners.
American UHNW	Warmer, more direct, more informal in address, and considerably more demanding about speed and responsiveness. Formality can read as coldness. Adjust.
Gulf and royal households	High formality, strict hierarchy, and cultural and religious observance that you are expected to know without being told. Learn the calendar, the greetings and the boundaries before your first day, never during it.
Asian family offices	Age, seniority and face govern everything. Never correct anyone senior in front of anyone. The indirect refusal is a genuine refusal, and hearing it correctly is a skill.
Tech wealth	Informality bordering on the anti-ceremonial, combined with severe privacy and data discipline. Do not confuse the casual dress with a casual standard: it is often the most exacting house of all.

The error to avoid is the one nearly everyone makes: assuming that the codes you have just learned are universal. They are not. **What is universal is the attentiveness that lets you read a house within a week, and adjust without ever announcing that you have.**

CHAPTER IX

The tells

How an outsider is identified, in four seconds

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Recognise the tells in others, and eliminate them in yourself.

Understand that none of them will ever be mentioned to you.

Here is the list. Read it slowly, and be honest: at least two of these are yours.

- The word "luxury", or any of its family. The fastest tell there is.
- A visible logo. On a bag, a belt, a scarf, a phone case.
- Perfume that enters the room first.
- A telephone placed on a table. Face down changes nothing.
- Laughter louder than the room.
- Photographing anything. The food, the view, the table you laid so beautifully.
- Commenting on the price or the value of an object. Including admiringly. Especially admiringly.
- An anecdote about a previous employer. This one does not merely mark you as an outsider. It ends the conversation, and often the candidacy.
- Bluffing a name. A house, a vintage, a designer, a school.
- Superlatives. Amazing, incredible, stunning, iconic. Restraint is the code; enthusiasm is the tell.

Notice what unites every item on that list: **each one is a small act of self-display**. The scent, the logo, the volume, the photograph, the anecdote, the bluff. In this world, the display is always the error, and it is always the thing that is noticed.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Every tell is a form of self-display, and every one of them is noticed in silence.

You will not be corrected. You will be trusted less.

Find your own three this week. Everyone has three.

Glossary of the module

Code, An unwritten convention by which a group recognises its own, never explained to newcomers.

Understatement, The governing aesthetic of this world. Precision instead of praise, and silence instead of superlatives.

Patina, The wear that age gives to fine materials. Treasured as proof of endurance, never polished away.

Silver service, Transferring food from platter to plate with spoon and fork in one hand. A trained skill.

Black tie / white tie, Evening dress codes. White tie is the more formal, and the more unforgiving.

The tell, A small, unconscious act of self-display that identifies an outsider instantly.

The bluff, Pretending to recognise a name. The fastest way to lose credibility permanently.

Restraint, The code that contains all the others: study everything, display nothing.

Self-assessment

Answer in writing, from memory. Bring the two you found hardest to your session.

1. Why can a code never be explained to a newcomer? Answer in terms of its function.
2. Give the mathematical rule about the word "luxury", and explain what it actually measures.
3. Rewrite these as a professional would: "It was an amazing evening at a really exclusive place." "I finally managed to get you an incredible table." "That is a stunning luxury car."
4. Write the four sentences from Chapter III, from memory, and say when each is used.
5. A name is mentioned that you do not recognise. Give your exact words.
6. Why is brevity a status signal? What does a long explanation ask for?
7. What is the governing rule of dress, and what is the test that verifies it?
8. The invitation says black tie. The principal is dressed in a business suit and about to leave. What do you say, word for word, and what do you do next?
9. Name six of the ten tells, and identify the single thing they all have in common.
10. Which three of the tells are yours? Be honest. This is the only question in this module that matters.

Further study

- The Dictionary of Luxury, which accompanies this programme. Read every entry this week. Module 4 will assume it.
- Listen, in any room you are ever in, for the word "luxury". Count it. You will learn more from that exercise in a month than from any book.
- Study one great house, one great maison and one great estate properly: its history, its makers, its vocabulary. Depth in one subject reads as culture. Breadth in none reads as a search engine.
- Watch how the most senior person in any room holds themselves, and notice how little they do. Then do less than that.

ÉMILIE'S NOTE

Reserved. This is where I add what I saw, in my own words.

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